

⚡ RAPID DOWNLOAD #7: STATUSES

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Read this the first time a PC or a Challenge takes a status:

Statuses are special tags that describe a condition like *injured*, *restrained*, *boosted*, or *charmed*. They have a **tier** from 1 to 6 that indicates their intensity. Like tags, statuses can affect your actions and rolls for better or for worse.

Every character, whether a PC or a Challenge, has a **Limit** of how much it can take of any given status. When a character takes a status with a tier equal to their Limit, known as maxing out the Limit, that character is temporarily overcome by the status. If the tier exceeds the Limit, that character is permanently overcome by the status.

For PCs, the Limit is 5 for all statuses, with 6 becoming permanent, killing or forever transforming your PC. For Challenges, the Limit is different for each type of status, something you can discover by trial and error or by studying the Challenge.

In tracked conflicts, Challenges will try to impede or defeat your character by giving you statuses as Consequences. You in return can overcome Challenges by using your player actions to give them statuses and exceed their Limits. You can also take action to remove negative statuses from yourself or remove the Challenges' positive statuses.

Read this the first time a status stacks:

When a PC or Challenge takes a status that is similar to one they already have, both statuses **stack**, becoming one. On the tracking card of the existing status, mark the tier of the new status next to the existing tier. A status can have multiple tiers marked this way (e.g., 4, 3, 1) but only the highest is considered the actual tier of the status.

If the incoming tier is already marked, mark the next unmarked box to the right of that tier. For example, if you have a tier-3 status and you take another tier-3 status, mark tier 4 instead.

Read this the first time a PC or a Challenge takes a progress status:

Statuses are also used to track processes, countdowns, or evolving situations, like a ticking time bomb, a dark ritual, or closing distance in a chase scene. You can take action to push the process forward or backwards, using the **Advance** and **Set Back** Effects respectively. Challenges advance or set back a process as Consequences.

If and when the Limit of the progress status is reached, something happens: the bomb goes off, the ritual is completed, or the chase ends, which could mean a Challenge has been overcome or, conversely, set off new and usually much worse Consequences, such as a mythological beast being summoned.

🔧 HACKING DEEPER

Statuses are special tags that describe a transient condition (unlike power, weakness, and story tags, which represent people, things, and innate abilities and qualities). They describe the current state or condition of a character or thing, such as being *wounded*, *flush-with-money*, *wanted-for-questioning*, *enchanted*, *behind-cover*, and so on. Statuses are marked with a green highlight.

Each status consists of a **tag**, which describes the nature of the status, and its **tier**, which indicates its intensity or severity. Tier 1 represents the mildest effect and tier 6 represents the maximum effect. It is possible to inflict higher tiers than 6, but only for the purpose of making mitigation more difficult (see **Mitigating a Status**, page 105). If after all reductions have been applied a PC or Challenge would receive a status with a tier higher than 6, it instead becomes tier 6.

TIER	INTENSITY
-	No effect
1	Mild
2	Minor
3	Major
4	Dramatic
5	Incapacitating
6	Lethal or permanently transformative

GIVING A STATUS

PCs and Challenges can give statuses to themselves or to other characters and objects. A character that attacks another character can give them *wounded*; a character that shields another character can give them *shielded*; and a character can give themselves *aiming*, *confident*, *firewalled*, *stealthy*, and so on, achieving any desirable effect.

- Players and their PCs give statuses using the Effects **Attack, Disrupt, Influence, Enhance, or Advance**. Each tier in the status given costs 1 Power.
- The MC and her Challenges give statuses as Consequences. The MC may choose to give any number of statuses at any tier when delivering Consequences. Challenge Profiles provide recommended statuses and tiers to give based on the Challenge's actions.

When giving a status, the player or the MC who is giving the status chooses its tag. Take a tracking card and mark the status and its tier.

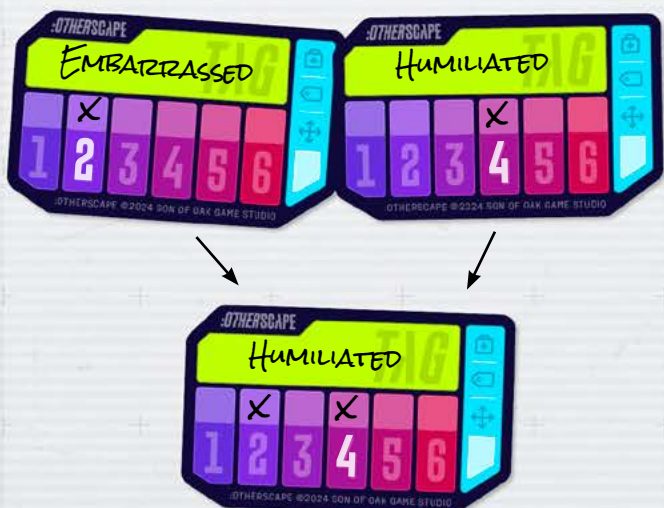
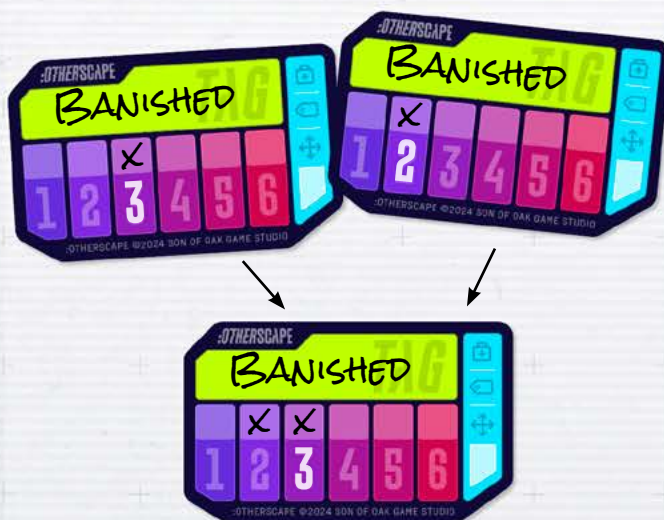


STACKING STATUSES

When a status of a specific tag is given to a character that already has a status of the same or similar tag, these statuses stack. This may reflect various types of injuries inflicted on the same combatant, or multiple banishing incantations forcing a banshee away. Every time the tier of a status increases, its tag may be updated to reflect its new intensity. For example, a cyberspace performer that has given their audience *amazed-3* and then *amazed-3* again may revise it to *wildly-enthusiastic-4*.

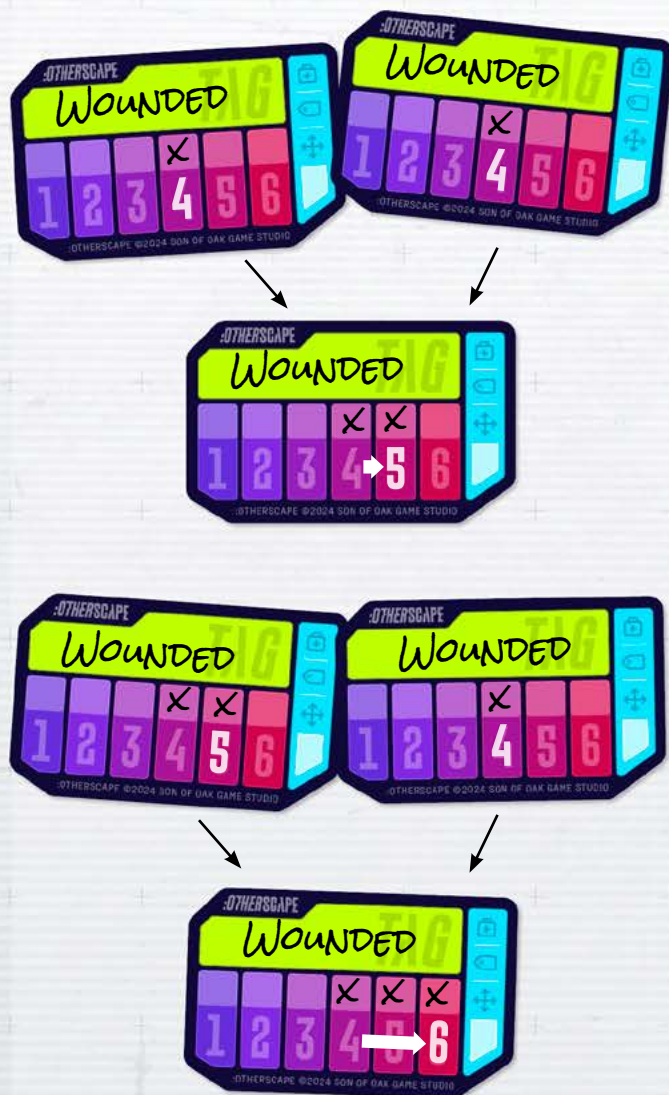
When an incoming tier stacks on an existing tier, simply mark the new tier in addition to the existing tier. Going forward, the tier of the status is the highest tier marked.

Example: A *banished-3* spirit that takes *banished-2* marks the box for tier 2, but the status tier remains 3. A socialite first *embarrassed-2* and then *humiliated-4* ends up with a tier-4 *humiliated*.



If the tier you are adding is already marked, move up the tiers until you find an unmarked tier and mark that. This means lower-tier statuses can gradually build up to deadly effects.

For example, when a character that is *wounded-4* is dealt another *wounded-4*, mark the next unmarked tier to the right of 4, which is tier 5, resulting in *wounded-5*. If that character took another *wounded-4*, they would have reached *wounded-6* (skipping tier 4 and tier 5 which are already marked), which would probably spell death for them.



MITIGATING A STATUS

If a PC receiving an incoming status is able to **Mitigate** it and wishes to do so, the player may temporarily receive the spotlight (out of turn) to make a mitigation roll (see **Mitigating Effects**, page 112). If successful, the player can use the **Mitigate** Effect to reduce the tier of the status they would receive. For every point of Power spent on **Mitigating**,

the incoming status is reduced by one tier. If reduced to tier zero, the incoming status is ignored altogether.

Tags that help the PC avoid or resist the status are helpful (such as *body armor* when avoiding gunfire), while tags that limit the PC's defense or attacker tags that empower the attack are impeding the **Mitigating** action (such as an enemy shooting *armor-piercing* rounds when a PC is soaking the gunfire with armor).

Status mitigation only applies to an incoming status and it is resolved before a status stacks with any existing statuses. Note that mitigation cannot reduce the tier of an existing status, it can only affect an incoming one. Reducing the tier of an existing status requires taking an action with the **Restore**, **Set Back**, or **Weaken** Effects.

Challenges do not mitigate statuses; instead, they reduce incoming statuses by brandishing defensive statuses and tags, like *shielded-3* or *impervious to ridicule*, weakening the PC's Power to attack and inflict statuses on them.

REMOVING A STATUS

PCs and Challenges can remove statuses from themselves or from other characters and objects. This could represent the character fixing a *malfunctioning-3* piece of tech, healing a comrade's *gunshot-wound-4*, or dispelling an enemy's protective spell that is keeping them *warded-2*.

- PCs remove statuses using the Effects **Weaken**, **Restore**, or **Set Back**. Each tier removed costs 1 Power.
- The MC and her Challenges remove status tiers as Consequences. The MC may choose to remove any number of statuses and any number of tiers when delivering Consequences. Challenge Profiles provide recommended statuses and tiers to remove based on the Challenge's actions.

When removing tiers from a stacked status, move each mark one box to the left for each tier removed, going from the lowest to the highest mark. A mark that is pushed past (lower than) tier 1 is removed (erased) completely.

For example, if a character who is *confident-2* then takes *confident-4*, they have *confident-4*, with 2 and 4 marked. If someone then removes 1 tier of confidence from that character, both the 2 mark and the 4 mark are pushed 1 box left, resulting in 1 and 3 marks, or *confident-3*. If the status is instead reduced by 3 tiers, 4 is pushed to 1, and 2 is removed, resulting in *confident-1*.



Remove 1 tiers,
Shift by 1 spot



Remove 2 tiers,
Shift by 2 spots



Remove 3 tiers,
Shift by 3 spots

Every time the tier of a status is reduced, its tag may be updated to reflect its new intensity. For example, software that was *stuck-in-a-loop-3* and was debugged to tier 1 may now be only *glitching-1*.

ROLLING WITH A STATUS

Statuses modify the Power of relevant PC actions. Like other tags, statuses can be irrelevant, positive, or negative for any specific action. When a PC takes action to which a status is relevant, they:

- Subtract the tier of their highest negative status from the Power of the action (e.g., *wanted-3* decreases the Power of an action to sneak by corporate police)
- Add the tier of their highest positive status to the Power of the action (e.g., *alert-2* increases the Power of an action to stand guard)

A status could be relevant whether it is attached to the acting character or to another character or object. For example, a PC who is *unstable-2* and is shooting at a target that is *behind-cover-4* across a *dark-1* plaza, will be affected by all three statuses, but because only the highest negative status applies, their Power will be reduced by 4.

Unlike PCs, Challenges don't count Power and therefore are not affected by statuses in the same way. Instead, statuses on Challenges usually affect the Power of PC's actions against them. An *evasive-2* drone will impose -2 Power on a PC attempting to shoot it, while an *off-balance-1* sniper will grant +1 Power to any PC attempting to push them over a ledge or mitigate their shot.

The **No Double Dipping** rule (page 89) applies to all tags, including statuses. If both the action and the mitigation would be affected by the same status, it can only be applied to the action and is ignored when counting Power for the mitigation.

LIMITS

In addition to modifying the Power of PC actions, statuses indicate when a PC or a Challenge is overcome by a condition. The maximum tier of a status a PC or Challenge can take is called their **Limit**. When a PC or Challenge takes a status at their Limit tier, they are **overcome** or **incapacitated**, and cannot take any more actions to which this status applies. This is also referred to as **maxing out** the Limit. If they take a status at a tier higher than their Limit, the effects are **permanent**, **lethal**, or **transformative** – the MC decides how so.

Each status requires a different interpretation. If a PC is overcome due to being *wounded*, they could be incapacitated or out cold, with the next step being quite possibly lethal, meaning they have died. If they were overcome by being *hypnotized*, they may be completely given to their master's control, while going over that Limit would mean they are permanently brainwashed. If they were overcome by being *humiliated*, perhaps they can no longer take social actions, and then become a social pariah if the status exceeds the Limit.

All statuses can have a Limit, including positive ones. Too much of a good thing is dangerous, and even *energized* can turn negative when it reaches a Limit, incapacitating and even killing the affected character.

A PC that is overcome in one aspect may still be able to take actions with other faculties. For example, if a PC is *restrained-5*, they may still be able to talk themselves out of a bad spot. This is not usually the case for Challenges (see **Overcoming Challenges**, below).



The default Limit for PCs for any status is tier 5, with tier 6 becoming permanent (see the **Optional Rules: Deadly Conflicts** for alternatives).

OVERCOMING CHALLENGES

Challenges have a different Limit for each status that could normally overcome them and these are listed in the Challenge profile. Challenge Limits are marked with a **red** highlight.

OPTIONAL RULE: LOWERING PC LIMITS

If you want to play an even grittier, deadlier game, consider lowering the default Limit for PCs to 4 (5 is permanent) or even 3 (4 is permanent). PCs must then rely more heavily on their tags to shield them from incoming statuses. Lowering this default limit will lead to PCs looking for cover at every opportunity, always attempting to have the element of surprise, and still becoming incapacitated or defeated, and possibly dying, much more often. This in turn will give your game a more bleak outlook.

Here are some common Limits you will encounter:

- **Hurt-or-subdue**: The generic Limit for physically overcoming a character so that they can't fight back. There are many different statuses of physical harm or subdual that could go towards this Limit, and the MC should allow different forms of harm or subdual to stack. Depending on the force used, maxing out this Limit could mean anything from restraint to incapacitation, and exceeding the Limit could mean anything from surrender to death.
- **Convince, threaten**: A Challenge with this Limit is harder to sway than most; a quick outcome won't cut it and the PCs will have to max out this Limit in order to get the Challenge to take a desired action. (The MC can always ignore this if she chooses to go with a quick outcome.)
- **Banish**: A Challenge with this Limit is usually a Conjunction created by a Source, and can be mystically overcome and expelled from the scene.
- **Crash or take-over**: This Limit represents crashing or taking control of a network node. When maxed out, it can no longer act against the PCs, either because it is inoperational or under the PCs' control. This could be applied to a physical piece of tech, such as a server, a drone, or cyberware, or to a digital entity, like a domain, a program or a Harnessed avatar.

- **Catch/outrun:** This polar Limit represents a chase. If the pursuer maxes out *catch* first, they have reached the fleeing party and blocked their path of escape. If those fleeing max out *outrun*, they escape their pursuer.

The MC may come up with new Limits for a Challenge on the fly. This could be useful when the PCs give a Challenge a status that would lead to overcoming it but the Challenge doesn't list a Limit for the specific status that the PCs are imposing. Or, the players or the MC have come up with a new way this Challenge can be overcome, and the MC would like to reflect it with a Limit. The tier of the Limit determines how hard it is to overcome the Challenge in this new way.

For example, Wilson and Unagi are fighting some Nezumi gangsters on a high hanging cable bridge in the Ghost Market. Unagi uses her climbing gear to swing into the gangsters and knock them off the bridge, giving them *knocked-over* and hopefully not falling over herself. Since falling off the bridge would spell instant death, the MC determines this will lead to the gangsters' defeat,

COMMON NON-LIMIT STATUSES

The following common statuses are not used to overcome an adversary by maxing out their Limit; instead, they are used to boost or weaken specific types of actions and mitigation.

Firewalled: A defensive program that hinders hacking attempts either in VR or nearspace.

Alert: Helps a PC notice hidden dangers and avoid being surprised, or hinders PCs from hiding or sneaking around a Challenge.

Shielded: A shield against physical and energy attacks including strikes, projectiles, fire, etc.

Warded: A barrier against Mythic powers and manifestations whether mental, physical, spiritual, etc.

Tagged: A digital mark that helps the tagger find and track the target for surveillance, hacking, weapon targeting, etc.

Malfunctioning: A technical issue hindering the use of the affected system or item.

Jammed: A communication or control malfunction hindering the use of the affected system or item.

Bad-rap: Damage to one's street reputation, hindering social interactions where capability or reliability matter.

and therefore it deserves its own Limit. She chooses *topple-over* and gives it the same tier as the Nezumi gangsters' *hurt-and-subdue* Limit, which is 3. Now they can track exactly which gang members take a permanent dive down the Ghost Market when Unagi slams into them.

When a Challenge is overcome by maxing out their Limit, they cease posing a problem for the PCs in the narrative.

A tactical drone can be *destroyed:3*, a skyscraper could be *scaled:4*, or a rogue AI *controlled:3*; in either case they no longer pose an issue for the PCs.

Some Challenges are immune to certain statuses. Such immunities are listed as a Limit of -. For example, a ghost could have a *hurt:-* immunity.

DURATION OF STATUSES

Statuses stay in the game until removed or until they expire in the narrative. For example, a PC who is *life-of-the-party-2* will remain so until the status is removed by another PC or the MC, until they leave, or until the party ends.

Unless their tier exceeds a specific Limit, statuses are not meant to stay in the game permanently and should expire after a while. When a status turns permanent because it exceeded a Limit, the MC chooses how to interpret it in the narrative.

POLAR STATUSES

Some statuses are the polar opposite of others: hot/cold, friendly/hostile, hidden/exposed, and so on. A PC or a Challenge can never have two polar statuses at the same time. When a character receives a status that is opposite to an existing status they have, remove a number of tiers in the greater status equal to the tier of the lower status. If the incoming status is greater, change the tag of the status to the new polarity.

For example, if a character who is *hostile-3* takes a *friendly-2* status, they become *hostile-1* ($3 - 2 = 1$). If the same *hostile-3* character took *friendly-4* instead, they would become *friendly-1* ($3 - 4 = -1$).

COMPELLING STATUSES

A compelling status is a status that includes a directive, explicit or implicit, and which therefore compels the target to act according to that directive. This could be *enraged*, *hacked*, *hypnotized*, *charmed*, *friendly*, *convinced*, and so on.

When a PC takes a compelling status, it hinders every action that PC takes that goes against the directive of the status. If the directive is to take specific action, such as attacking an ally, even trying to avoid taking this action by doing nothing

is considered an action modified by the status. At tier 5, the player is unable to even attempt actions that go against the directive. If the status grants complete control over the PC (such as *brainwashed*), the player temporarily loses control of the PC to their controller (whether the MC or another player's PC). At tier 6, these effects become permanent.

When a Challenge takes a compelling status and attempts to act against its directive, the PCs can use it as a helpful status when mitigating the Challenge's actions. For example, an adversary that is *charmed-4* and who attempts to attack the PCs grants 4 additional points to the Power of the mitigating action. If a Challenge Limit is maxed out by a compelling status, it temporarily cannot take actions that go against the directive. If the status grants complete control over the Challenge (such as *brainwashed*), the MC temporarily loses control of the Challenge, who then becomes a secondary character for the controlling PC. The MC should provide the player of the controlling PC with story tags to represent this new secondary character. When the Limit is exceeded by 1 tier or more, these effects become permanent (although any story tags representing the controlled Challenge may still expire normally).

PROGRESS STATUSES

Statuses can be used to track progress towards a goal or a definitive moment, such as constructing a tank drone, performing a ritual, completing a transformation, or charging up a weapon. Such a status is referred to as a progress status.

PCs and Challenges add to a progress status and reduce it as usual by using Effects; PCs specifically use **Advance** to add to a progress status and **Set Back** to reduce it. Based on the narrative, actions that push the process towards completion add to the status, while actions that reverse progress reduce the status (e.g., sabotaging the construction of the tank drone) or give it the opposite statuses (see **Polar Statuses** above).

When the Limit of a progress status is maxed out, the goal is achieved or the turning point happens: the tank is built, the ritual is complete, or the weapon is charged-up. Narrative events and special rules may be triggered at this point, regardless of who has the spotlight: the PC's rival reveals their new tank, a hungry ghost is summoned into the scene, or the wielder of the charged-up weapon fires it.

Progress statuses are most often used to track Challenges as they build up towards a major Consequence or when tracking a Challenge progress against a PC's. However, the MC can track a PC's narrative goal with such a status, for

example, *promotion-4*. If a PC wants to achieve a goal that has game effects beyond just the narrative, they should instead use Effects or replace a theme, and describe the outcome using tags and/or statuses.

Depending on the narrative logic of the status, progress statuses may ignore the rules on overcoming a PC or Challenge by hitting or exceeding their Limits. A PC who has been working on a project or a Challenge who is casting a ritualistic spell is not overcome when they max out their own progress status (rather, the *task* is "overcome" and completed). Similarly, a PC who is chasing a thief and maxes out the thief's *catch* status does not automatically overcome the thief, but they have them pinned down. On the other hand, some Challenges are all about their progress Limits: a PC traversing through a wasteland Challenge and completing the journey does overcome the Challenge.

OPTIONAL RULE: STOPPING THE DEATH SPIRAL

By default, *Otherscape* is in **Death Spiral Mode**: getting hurt makes it more likely to get even more hurt. For example, when you *injure* an enemy, this status could empower your next attack against them (e.g., if they can't dodge or take cover) or it could empower your mitigation of their attacks (e.g., if they can't aim well). The same is true about you: when you get *injured*, it can increase the chances of failing your next action, which could then result in getting even more hurt as Consequences, or it could make it harder to mitigate incoming damage. (A status can't affect both action and mitigation at the same time, see **No Double Dipping**, page 89).

This reflects the dire straits of dystopian cyberpunk fiction: life is cheap, combat is fast and brutal, and the first shot that hits you might mean you're already dead. Things tend to rapidly deteriorate, forcing the protagonists to make greater sacrifices to stay in the game (see **Power Options**, page 121).

Optionally, you can remove the death spiral by adding a simple rule: a status that counts against a Limit cannot empower actions that add statuses to that Limit (or depower actions that mitigate them). With this rule, being *injured* doesn't directly affect a character's chances of survival; it only measures how close they are to being overcome. This in turn will slow down conflict, allowing the PCs to make some mistakes and adjust their strategy.